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David Spinozza

David Spinozza has been a first-call guitarist for recordings and gigs since the early 1970s. His lengthy list of collaborators includes three of the four Beatles, James Taylor, Paul Simon, and Steve Gadd.

Dave was interviewed via Zoom on September 27, 2025 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have David Spinozza with me this morning in, let's see, we're in New Hartford, New York after a gig. Thanks for coming.

DS: Nice to be here.

MR: Yeah. I was lucky enough to hear you play last night and we'll talk about that, but I'm going to quote you, this is just from like a half an hour ago at breakfast.

DS: Yeah.

MR: You're a very quotable guy, and you said, "I'm a quick learner and a quick forgetter."

DS: Yes.

MR: Remember you said that? And in the brief time you were sort of describing your career I realized that you've been the recipient of some moments that you didn't necessarily cause to happen but like happy accidents?

DS: I would say, yes, yes. Probably because when I came up I was a rhythm & blues guitar player basically. I wouldn't – I never really considered myself a jazz guitarist. Because I certainly listened to a lot of jazz players: Wes Montgomery, Joe Pass, people like that, you know, Chuck Wayne. I knew all these guitarists. I knew who they were. But I was mostly playing rhythm & blues. I had horn bands and I learned to arrange because the horns would say, "Well what do we play?" And I started to figure out how to write for horns and stuff like that. So I became kind of a chameleon in the music business. And that's how I got started.

MR: You know you just gave me a flash because I was able to interview Howard Johnson.

DS: Oh sure. I know him well.

MR: And he talked about getting a call to play a John Lennon session, which I know you had done.

DS: Yeah.

MR: But it might have been before. At any rate John Lennon just had this thought that when you get in professional horn players that something magic just happens. Like they know what to do.

DS: Like they know what parts to play.

DS: Yeah. That's funny.

MR: So where did you access in your head how to write for horns? Was there something you heard growing up that you were paying attention to?

DS: Well I always listened – I used to listen to – it was funny, even some of my guitar lines come from horn players. I got most of how I play jazz from listening to horn players. Like I would listen to Lee Morgan for instance like that, I had that record "Sidewinder" you know. And I'd arranged that a few times for my band. But I was studying music theory in high school. I had a really good music theory teacher. So he would teach me how to take dictation, how to write stuff out, and so I was learning how to do that anyway, and I sort of led off the guitar, like the voicings on the guitar are almost like drop two voicings which, you know, is a big band style of writing. And I would just write stuff off the guitar and write it out for horn players and they'd play it and it sounded good. And I was able to make four horns sound pretty big just because of the voicings. So I started that at like 13, 14 years old I was already writing for horns and stuff with my band. So I've always had like two trumpets, an alto sax, a bari and a tenor or something, you know four or five horns. And that's how I started writing.

MR: If you're writing for just two, did you discover like what's the most effective thing of the notes in the chord – if it's just two horns.

DS: Two horns to me, it's always the third and the seventh. You know the first thing I would do is drop the tonic, you know, drop the fifth, you don't need that. It's going to be implied in the piano part and the bass line and this and that. So it was always like yeah, the third and the seventh.

MR: Isn't it interesting how, you know the music business has changed dramatically but the idea of, "Let's start a band" is still there. Like what drives that? What drove you into this business?

DS: Into the business of a band? Well when I was a kid I used to go to this place called the Canada Lounge which was in Mamaroneck, New York. And there was a band called The Orchids. And they were an R&B band. The guitar player was named Link Chamberlain. He was ahead of his time. He could bend the strings and do all this stuff that I'd never really heard. It was sort of almost like country – like country playing. And this was before light gauge strings, but Link had I guess became an expert at bending the string notes. That's the first time I heard that type of playing. And for me I got turned on, that's why I play the way I play today, 'cause I was inspired by this guy Link. And Link would listen to like Roy Buchanan, James Burton who played with Elvis Presley, there were guys that played that certain style. They were Telecaster players, then I became a Telecaster player, because I sort of idolized Link, and I'd go listen to him in that club,

horns in that band. So they only had like two, so I said, "I'm going to have four." So my band is going to have four horns. And that was the thing. And we also had choreography – we were like a show band. We did steps, we did all that kind of stuff. I was a showman, I used to front the band sometimes and dance. And sometimes I had a guitar player and I wouldn't even play the guitar, I would just be the front man and I would sing and dance and I was all in to that whole thing in the beginning also.

MR: Did you have aspirations, as most bands do, of like, "Let's make a record. Let's get a deal."

DS: Well the thing was, it's funny you said that. We were sort of a cover band. We didn't really write a lot of originals. We were covering a lot of stuff: James Brown, Otis Redding, you know we played some Joe Tex. We were doing a lot of covers. So I don't think we really dreamed too much about having a record deal. And then finally we did write some songs. We got a one deal thing with Mercury. I had a band called Giant and we did one album. And I wrote most of the stuff. But we weren't thinking original songs, and that's usually where it comes from. You have to write original material to get a record deal you know.

MR: Did you have an option of another line of work? Because last night I heard you saying that you know I just worked weekends, it never occurred to me that I might make a living. I might be extrapolating on what you said, but was there another option for you?

DS: No. I had no other options. No. I mean all I did was play the guitar. I was a high school dropout, I never went to music college, I don't have a degree in music or anything like that. I left school in the middle of the eleventh grade, went on the road with one of my bands, a ten-piece band. We went down to Miami and we had to play opposite Wayne Cochran and the CC Riders that blew us out of the water. I mean we were a good band but that band was killing. I remember going back and going, "I want to do this, I want to be a musician." And I said to my mother, "I don't want to go back to school, I just wanna' -- " and then I left my band and started getting calls do to session work. That why, as I told you earlier, I never really learned a lot of the standards or anything like that because by the time I was 17-1/2, 18 I started getting calls from Manhattan to go play recording sessions.

MR: How – why? Why did people know your name to have you do that?

DS: I think what happened was, one of my friends growing up was Tommy Mottola, who became the president of CBS/Columbia. But at the time he wanted to be a singer, like a Fabian or one of those "good hair" guys, you know, that sang. And he was doing a demo for a company and he said, and he wanted me to play on the record. And there was an arranger named Horace Ott, who went on to produce YMCA and all that stuff. He was an

doing the session. Tommy said, "Do you mind if I bring my friend David in to play the guitar?" And Horace said, "Well as long as he can keep up because he's going to be playing with session musicians and if he can keep up it's okay but if not, -- you know." So I went to the session and the rhythm section was Chuck Rainey, Bernard Purdie, Richard T, and me. And that's the first time I heard those guys play. And I obviously could keep up and everybody liked me, and then Horace Ott started calling me to play on his sessions. So then I was doing maybe two sessions a week for Horace. That's how it started out.

MR: And you were how old then?

DS: About 18. And then I'd take the train in from Mamaroneck, New York which was about thirty minutes from the city, and drag my amp through Grand Central Station, and go to sessions for Horace Ott. And that started me with playing dates. And then it was just word of mouth, people heard about me and I started getting calls for other jobs.

MR: You must have been a quick learner.

DS: Yeah. A quick learner and quick forgetter.

MR: A quick learner and a quick forgetter. But the whole thing about being in the studio, okay let's double track that, let's all the little stuff that happens, let's punch in the guitar for a measure. That's like even if you had gone to music school you wouldn't have learned that.

DS: No. No.

MR: It's just like on-the-job training.

DS: Right. It was totally on-the-job training. I mean and I got to sit next to musicians that were just absurdly good. And I was always worried, "Oh my God they're going to find out I'm not as good as they think I am." I was pretty stressed out with the musicians I'd played with were just ridiculous, I mean I came from a little town, I was the big fish in the little town. All of a sudden New York City it was a different ballgame.

MR: Do you remember the first time you did a session where you sat down and it was an uh oh, maybe because everything was like written out?

DS: Oh yeah. Oh I'll give you a good one. Oliver Nelson. Right? And I get this call and I go in and it's a whole sax section you know, it was a big band and me. I forgot what record it was for something, and it was for an introduction, an eight-bar introduction with the sax section in unison with the guitar, playing lines, like bebop, fast bebop lines. And I looked at it and it just all looked like black to me. I couldn't figure out what it was. And thank God the tape machine broke and somebody said, "Guys, take a 15 minute break." And now the guys on the session were like Jerome Richardson, Jerry Dodgion, Eddie Daniels – you know, that bunch. Ronnie Cuber. And they were struggling playing the

oh, and I'm supposed to play it in unison. So I'll never forget, I took the music, I went into the bathroom, because I had studied theory so I could solfege in my head and I figured if I could sing it to myself in my head then I could translate it to the guitar. So I went in the stall and I actually was so stressed out that this was the session where they're going to find out I'm not that good, I threw up in the toilet. I was so nervous. Then I just sat there and kept looking at it and like learned it in my head. Then the 15 minutes was over and I went back, stomped it off and I played it. That was the date I thought they're going to find out I'm not that good, and this is the end of my career.

MR: I can just see it now. The sax players will even go, "That cat played that thing on the guitar, wow, he's really good."

DS: When the sax section said, "Can we try it a little slower?" I said, "I don't have a prayer." They wanted to play it slower. And you know, you're a sax player yourself, those guys read fly shit. I mean I was like, "You've got to be kidding me, I have to play this with them?"

MR: On the opposite end of the spectrum, when you go to a session and you get nothing but chord charts –

DS: Not always. Not everyone knows how to write for the guitar that well because it's the physi – you have to know the physicality of the guitar to write for it, especially if you're writing multiple notes and stuff like that, chord voicings and stuff. You really have to know the instrument. And a lot of arrangers don't necessarily know the instrument. But you never knew. Some days you walked in and they'd want me to make up the guitar part, you know they were just chords. And that's also part of the thing about being a studio musician, you have to know when you walk in there am I making up a part today to make this song sound better? Or is everything going to be written and I'm just asked to play exactly what's on the page. You just never knew from session to session which, you know, which thing it was going to be.

MR: If it was a record for backing up a singer, a singer's record,

DS: Yeah.

MR: Did you usually hear a scratch vocal or something?

DS: Some sessions.

MR: Because it affects the way you play if you're hearing what's the singer doing.

DS: Yeah. It's different. Sometimes they would call it a dummy vocal, meaning it wouldn't be the final vocal, that somebody would just sing the song. It might not even be the artist. They would just sing along so you could hear them while they're playing it. But some arrangers like Van McCoy for instance was an arranger –

MR: Of "The Hustle."

DS: Of the Stylistics' stuff, when the Stylistics started doing stuff. And this was after they were out of Philly or wherever they were from originally. Then they started doing stuff in New York. And Van was so specific with his charts, you just read the charts, no vocal. You never heard the vocal until the record came out. And it was all – so once again you never knew which situation you were going to walk into. But Van wrote every note out that he wanted. So you just played it. Even though it was rhythm & blues it was written out. And you had to just play every part, we never heard the vocal until the record came out.

MR: Until you're in the car and you hear the radio.

DS: Well that track sounds familiar, and then I realized I had played on it. But I had never heard the melody. So there's a lot of things, it's always just like I said you just didn't know, every situation was different. And I think the thing that made the studio musicians studio musicians was our ability to adjust quickly and learn quickly and unlear – you just never knew, am I making a part up? Am I reading a part? So you really had to know which cap you're wearing that day.

MR: After you had done that for a bunch of years, did you ever turn anything down because of the kind of music it was?

DS: Not because of the kind of – I turned it down sometimes because if I didn't like the producer or the arranger, if I thought they were like taskmasters or something that I didn't agree with I would turn it down. Once I was established and was making enough money to say no, sometimes I would turn it down based on how much stress I thought the session was going to be you know.

MR: And the average session was four hours a day?

DS: Usually three hours, they would book it as three hours with a possible 20 or three hours with a possible 40, there was always this possible thing. They would say that so that you wouldn't book something right away. Like if you have a 10-1 they didn't want you to have a 1:30 booked somewhere because just in case they needed the overtime. So they would book sessions in three hour increments with a plus 20 or a plus 40.

MR: What would cause a studio musician to stop getting called?

DS: You would stop being called because the last session you played on you didn't rise to the occasion.

MR: The last session.

DS: Yeah. I mean to me you're always as good as your last call. And everybody lived in fear of that, of like oh my God here I couldn't sight read this thing or I was out of tune or whatever it was.

MR: And so the contractors would like –

DS: And the contractor would know and if the producers complained to the contractor, "I don't want to see that guy again" or whatever, that would be it. That's why it was so stressful because you really were only as good as your last phone call. You were never sure there was going to be another session. In fact there's a joke about it. There's two musicians or something, they're talking one day. And this one musician says to the other musician, "Did you hear last week I played a score for a movie?" And then the other one said, "Did you hear I met Marilyn Monroe? I'm sleeping with Marilyn Monroe." And he said, "Oh, by the way," he said, "did you hear I played this one session and I was a little out of tune." "Yeah I heard about that." That's kind of what it was like.

MR: That was the news.

DS: That was the news. Yeah. I heard about that.

MR: You mentioned producers, now you eventually got into production.

DS: I did, yeah.

MR: So on all these sessions, I'm just – this is a guess on my part but you were observing how producers worked.

DS: Yeah. I was learning. I was learning how to produce and I was learning how to arrange for singers, I mean how to write when there's a vocalist and I was paying attention to that. I was always a musical study. I was always studying. I took classical guitar lessons, I took orchestration lessons with a lady named Ariadna Mikeshina, she was a Russian composer. I studied with her for six years on my own so I didn't go to college or anything but I did it on my own. I studied classical guitar and orchestration. And I was always interested in how you write for singers and not get in the way of the vocal. And I was always fascinated by that.

MR: And your scorepads, did you have a line for what the singer was actually singing?

DS: Oh yeah. I'd always write the melody out first on the scorepad so I knew what the melody was, and then I'd write the rest of the stuff.

MR: And where did you get the melody from? Did someone send you a demo?

DS: Oh they'd send you a demo or maybe there was a lead sheet or something.

MR: And as a producer, did you have liberty to say this is the instrumentation I want?

DS: Yeah it would be a discussion and so you'd agree on what it should be.

MR: Did you play on the sessions you produced?

DS: Sometimes, but sometimes I would play afterwards because it was too much conducting the orchestra and stuff like that, than to play and conduct. I mean you can do that from the piano, piano conducting, but the guitar it's a little – so if I did I would usually overdub.

MR: And your scores were hand written.

MR: Pre Finale, pre Sibelius.

DS: Pre all that, all hand written.

MR: Did you ever make a mistake?

DS: Usually not because I was so worried about there being a mistake, you know you could get bogged down in rehearsal if a lot of the musicians are going, "Excuse me is that a C or a C sharp?" You know that kind of thing. So I would really go over each part and make sure, you know, that it was right. And then I had a copyist and then if the copyist saw something they'd say, "David, did you mean the C sharp there or was it a C natural?" So by the time I went to the studio it was copied and right. I mean I prided myself on nobody asking me a note question.

MR: And that gets passed down the chain too, like, "Yeah, David man, he's got his stuff together."

DS: Yeah and that's what happened, and then people realized you have your stuff together and you'll get called, because on a session you know the clock is on. In the recording session, you know Atlantic Records or A&M Records is paying for a three hour session for a 40-piece orchestra, you can't have people going, "Uh where is the coda? Do we repeat that or? You know you can't have that. So I prided myself on watching the arrangers that I looked up to that really took care of business, and I learned from them how to prepare a score and how to run a recording session.

MR: And how to write for strings?

DS: And how to write for strings and everything, yeah.

MR: Yeah. Because it's embarrassing if you like write something and the cellist goes, "Uh we don't play that low." You're like ouch.

DS: Yeah, well I prided myself on that too, I memorized all the ranges of all the instruments. I've never written a note that wasn't playable. And when the bari sax got that low A key in the '60s, I was yes! You know like all that kind of stuff. I learned all that stuff. I prided myself on knowing the range of the transpositions. On my next – first started writing I wrote transposed you know.

MR: The score?

DS: The score was transposed.

MR: Wow. I always had an issue with that.

DS: Now I don't do it so much, now in Sibelius because it'll do it, but back in the day I mean if it was a baritone sax I wrote in E flat. If it was the tenor sax I knew it sounded down a ninth. And if it was a trumpet you know it sounded down a tone. I mean I knew all the transpositions and all that stuff. I memorized all that.

MR: Did you save all your scores?

DS: I didn't. I used to throw them out right after the session, I'd throw them in the trash can. Yeah. I didn't think they'd be worth anything. I really didn't.

MR: And then you got into the jingle business.

DS: Yeah I got into the jingle business. And that was an interesting thing because a lot of guys wanted to do jingles because jingles the pay scale was really good, you were there for an hour and if the TV spot went national you make residuals, every 13 weeks you get a residual check, you know fifty bucks or something but it added up if you did a lot of them. So whatever, there was this guy named Joey Levine who basically was the Godfather of bubble gum music. He was the one that had that record "Yummy Yummy Yummy I Got Love in My Tummy." So I met him one day and I said to him, I said, "If I ever met the guy that sang that song I want to kill him, that's such a ridiculous song." And I told Joey. And he said, "You know that's really funny," he said, "you know I have a jingle business. Do you know how to put music on it, because I don't know how to write music, I don't know how to write it down. Do you know how to write it down?" I said yeah. He said, "Cause when I go to the sessions I have to sing parts." I go, "That's crazy, Joe." And I became his arranger. And he wrote all these great spots. I mean he wrote, "I Love My Mounds" you know, and Mounds, and Time Magazine, and all these things and I was the arranger on a lot of those spots because Joey needed somebody to conduct the band and write the stuff out. So for a while – fifteen years – I was in the jingle business just writing out Joey melodies.

MR: I find it fascinating that some of the most memorable hooky things come from as you say, people who can't write it down.

DS: Yeah.

MR: They just hear it.

DS: Yeah. Well we call them hummers.

MR: You called them hummers.

DS: Hummers. But they come up with – like Joey could come up with a hook in, like a two bar hook that you just say, "How the hell did you come up with that?" You or I could write for a 40-piece orchestra but I couldn't come up with a hook like that. So there's different talents within the whole musical world.

MR: Did you have to deal with the ad people who would come in and say things like, "Make it sound yellow."

DS: Yes. Oh yes, yes, yes. That was one of my least favorite things was dealing with the ad people but you know we called them "the suits." When the suits get here they're going to ask for this and they're going to ask for that, and you have to try to placate the situation and you do the best you can. Yeah. But I didn't have to go to a lot of those meetings

a few years at the tail end of the jingle business. And then I had to go to the meetings and do all that stuff. I didn't really care for it so I didn't last very long after that in that business. I didn't really care for it.

MR: Did you have time during this period to get out and play gigs, or did you even want to?

DS: Yeah. I was still gigging here and there you know, and had a little band with John Tropea, we did weekend stuff here and there. I didn't have to do that. And then I did Saturday Night Live for three years with Marini. For the first two years I was actually the conductor for '81 to '83. And then I played guitar in the band after that for a while. And so I did a whole bunch of different – my career was very eclectic.

MR: That's a – Saturday Night Live is another kind of pressure I would imagine.

DS: Yeah. Look live television, you know. That was a lot of pressure.

MR: And was it a day of rehearsal beforehand.

DS: Not really a day, just the same day a lot of times. 11:00 – you come in at noon and rehearse whatever song was going to be on that night. Then they would tape it. They'd do a taping around 7, 7:30. And they'd do a two hour taping but then they'd edit it down to an hour and a half when it was going to go live at 11:00 or whatever it was. So it was an all day Saturday thing mainly. It wasn't too much rehearsal for the band. Probably the cast yes, but not the band.

MR: What's your attitude about – there's a Saturday Night Live a couple of things where people come out an they're lip syncing.

DS: Oh yeah.

MR: They're just singing with tracks but they're not really – no they're singing but they're singing to tracks. Did that occur when you were on the band or was that later on?

DS: That didn't occur when I was on the band but when I did, the first time I did – now here's an interesting story: the first time I played Saturday Night Live I was working with Carly Simon. I was her musical director for about 2-1/2, 3 years. And she was going to be on the show singing "You're So Vain." And she has a little stage fright thing that kicks in every now and then so she didn't want to do it live. So we actually recorded it at the noon show. And this was in the '70s. And they recorded her thing so they plugged it in at night. She really didn't – she sang live but it was live in the video. They put the video in when it was her turn at night. That was the first time I think Saturday Night Live ever did that. So it wasn't really the Milli Vanilli thing on her not singing, but it wasn't live. We taped it at noon. They plugged it in when they said, "And now, Carly Simon." We had taped it.

MR: Being a musical director, did you know what the term meant?

DS: No. I became these things by accident. I became a session musician, I didn't know what a session musician was, I just wanted to play the guitar. It was like okay now you're a session musician. Okay. Now I'm a session musician. Whatever.

MR: And you played with Thad Jones-Mel Lewis.

DS: I did play with Thad Jones.

MR: I have to hear this story again.

DS: Well I used to go, on Monday nights I'd go down, because I was always loving big band stuff. And I would call myself, as far as jazz, I'd call myself a closet jazzer. 'Cause I practice jazz at home and I used to listen to Wes Montgomery records and you know, Joe Pass, and all that stuff. And I would learn the stuff but I never really played out. I never played jazz in a club or anything. I didn't do that. But I was fascinated with the arranging of big band stuff. So Monday nights I would go down to the Village Vanguard I think they played every Monday, and I'd go down there and Thad would see me sitting there all the time. And one time after about two months of going every Monday night, Thad comes up to me and he said, "You're a horn player, right?" I said, "No." He said, "Well you're here every Monday night what do you do?" I said, "I just love the band, I love the charts that Bobby Brookmeyer, "Willow Weep for me" I remember all that stuff and then Thad's charts and I said, "I just love the writing." And he said, "Well what do you play?" I said, "I'm a guitarist." And he said, "Well we're doing an album in a couple of weeks, do you want to play -- something like that. And somebody must have told him I was a good player. Jerome Richardson was – I knew Jerome, I knew Jerry Dodgion, Eddie Daniels a little bit. I didn't know them well. Jon Faddis was playing lead at the time with the band, and they were doing the record "Consummation." They had never had a guitar in that band and I wound up playing on that album.

MR: That's wild.

DS: Once again I just backed into it.

MR: So you were on that tune "Ahunk Ahunk"?

DS: Yeah I'm on "Ahunk Ahunk." That's me. Yeah. I remember feeling this is strange. The band never had a guitar and it's really funny because even when I write for big band I don't really hear a guitar in it. And I'm a guitarist. But when I write for big band I don't really think it has to have a guitar.

MR: Yeah.

DS: But it's just funny that I got asked to do it, and that was when Thad had that beautiful song "A Child is Born."

MR: Yeah.

DS: You know that ballad he wrote? Oh, gorgeous. I mean I heard it before he recorded it. I heard them play it on Monday nights on there and then they recorded it. I was like, "Oh man, what a beautiful, what a beautiful melody.

MR: Speaking of beautiful melodies, last night you played, Lou called one of your tunes and –

DS: You handing out money?

MR: Three dollars here. I'm looking for the card where I wrote your tune down.

DS: Oh.

MR: It was called "Doesn't She Know By Now."

DS: Oh yeah that's my song.

MR: Yeah. And I wrote down the first phrase [scats].

DS: Yeah.

MR: It goes with the title, "Doesn't She Know By Now."

DS: Yeah I do that sometimes, I write with the lyric in mind. I think of the lyric.

MR: So the song has a lyric?

DS: It doesn't have a lyric, just that.

MR: But it could. That's why I [inaudible].

DS: Well it's interesting you said, that somebody wrote a lyric to it that I didn't ask to. I can't remember her name right now. She wrote a lyric to it later. I just wrote it with the title. [scats] that thing. And in fact it was never really a full verse or anything but you know who sang on the record? Luther Vandross. And it's on my solo album. I had a solo album on A&M and Luther wrote and sang all the background parts. And all they sang through the whole song is "Doesn't she know by now."

MR: Do you still on occasion hear things, either on Sirius radio or wherever that you recognize yourself or you think you recognize yourself?

DS: I would recognize a song. I don't know if I'd recognize myself, but I'd recognize – I might recognize a song and then realize I played on it.

MR: Okay. Well I'm going to – this is – do you remember *DownBeat* Magazine used to do a blindfold test and these people would be put in this situation and they're trying to name the players.

DS: Oh name the players? Oh wow.

MR: Yeah.

DS: I don't know if I could do that.

MR: Some of the people were smart, like they didn't even try to. They would just talk about the song, "Oh I really liked that how -- " because if you're put on the spot to recognize somebody it can be a little – but I want to see if you –

DS: Are you putting me on the spot?

DS: Oh boy. You didn't tell me –

MR: So just listen to the guitar fills.

DS: I have no idea.

MR: And it fades off.

DS: Wow.

MR: That's you.

DS: That's me? What is that? What song is that?

MR: I have to tell you, this is a pretty odd story.

DS: I don't even recognize the song.

MR: Well 40 years ago I was in a rock band, and we, like all bands, were trying to find a record deal, and we had a producer and that was one of our songs. And the producer's name was Tom Bush and he took it to New York. He took our recording on the multi-track, at the time two inch tape.

DS: Right.

MR: You know, and for some reason he kept the vocals and he replaced the instruments.

DS: What?

MR: Yeah. He like, that's our singer and he replaced all the instruments. And I remember him coming back to Utica and playing it for us and we – first of all it was sort of like jeez he replaced us, thanks a lot. But I remember like, "Oh those are pretty cool guitar parts in there, who is that?" And he goes, "That's David Spinozza."

DS: Wow. I don't remember.

MR: And so you played on my record.

DS: I played on your record?

MR: 40 years ago.

DS: Wow. I had no idea. I've got to get a copy. I have to hear it. It's hard for me to hear it off the phone too, because I'm a little hard of hearing.

MR: Yeah, okay. But I just like the coincidence killed me.

DS: That's hysterical. So we worked together sort of. We worked together last night, we played the melody of the Duke Ellington.

MR: That's right, in unison.

DS: Yeah in unison. That was good. I was the third horn.

MR: But the way the business works is just like Bucky Pizzarelli told me these funny stories about John had to tell him that he played on certain songs.

DS: Right.

MR: You know because he just did so much of that that he wouldn't recognize –

DS: That was the same with me. I mean at the height of my career I was playing fifteen

either writing or in the studio, and sometimes like I said you'd play tracks and you wouldn't hear the vocal, you wouldn't hear the song, I wouldn't be able to recognize half, you know over half the stuff I played on. Soundtracks from movies and things like that, you know, how would you know?

MR: Did it become a chore?

DS: No. I enjoyed it. It was challenging and it was stressful. Like I said, I always lived in the fear, my biggest fear was they're going to find out that I'm not as good as they think I am. That was probably my biggest fear.

MR: Well if I went down your list of recording credits on whatever website it was.

DS: Right. A discography.

MR: A discography, page after page after page and it's probably incomplete but we might assume that the big names that pop out, you know three of the four Beatles and other names like that might have been the most memorable sessions for you. Is that necessarily true?

DS: Yeah, yeah. Because those people were, those records were visible. You were going to hear them all the time everywhere. So those things you remember. But I probably played on 80% of the stuff that never saw the light of day. That was the other thing. People say, "Oh you played on this hit record, you played on that hit record." Yeah but thousands of records you play on never see the light of day. You don't remember them and they never went anywhere. You think about how many – the percentage of people that have hit records – it's like winning the lottery. So most of the things you do you don't remember.

MR: And you don't necessarily ever hear them again either.

DS: I never hear them again, yeah, yeah.

MR: How do you keep track of all those sessions that you're actually getting paid for. Is that a union thing?

DS: Union. The union. I was in the musicians' union. I did mostly union work. I've done some non-union but it was mostly musicians' union. Yeah I was a member of the union since I was 14 years old. I joined it in Larchmont which is near Mamaroneck, New York. But then when I moved to the city I joined Local 802 and so I was with that union for over 50 years.

MR: Did they make you prove that you could play?

DS: No. No the union didn't know. You could just say you played the tambourine and probably get into the union, yeah. They didn't care. They didn't really care. There was no music test. Thank God, I might have failed.

MR: You've been in the union for a long time. You said you get your pay from the union.

DS: Yeah.

DS: I did. Yeah at one time I was MDing for Paul Williams the songwriter. You know he wrote "Rainy Days and Mondays" and he wrote "We've Only Just Begun." He was an unbelievable songwriter. And Kenny Asher and myself and a few other people he was going to go on the Mary Travers show from – remember Mary Travers? She had a show in England back in the '70s.

MR: From Peter, Paul & Mary?

DS: Peter, Paul & Mary. Yeah. So she had a TV show in England. So Paul brought me and Kenny Asher over to augment this – we were going to get a bass player and a thing – we're going to play a couple of shows, her TV show and something else. And when we got to the studio a union delegate, an English union delegate comes in and says, "You guys can't play on the TV show" to me and Kenny Asher. And I said, "Why not?" He said, "Well there has to be the same amount of musicians – you know we have to have a piano player and a guitar player in New York." There was a reciprocal union thing because there weren't – they had to hire a piano player. I could rehearse the band, I could rehearse them 'cause I did the charts. I rehearsed the band but they brought in another – they brought in an English guitar player and an English piano player, and Kenny and I were in London for a week and we had nothing to do so we went to Paris. Because we couldn't play any of the gigs we were supposed to do with Paul. We went to Paris and we just went around Paris and went to the Arc de Triomphe and all, you know the Champs-Elysees and we just made a trip out of it because we couldn't play a note in Europe.

MR: You can't make this stuff up.

DS: You can't make this stuff up because there had to be the same amount of musicians in America that were there. Some kind of union rule. I never really understood it, but all I know is we were not able to back up Paul Williams on the gigs we went over there to do.

MR: It wasn't exactly cultural exchange. There was – yeah, there was a beef.

DS: Yeah there was something. I don't know what it was. I never really got that involved with the union stuff. I was happy to be working you know.

MR: Is any of the – your anticipation of an event. Like you're going to play with Ringo Starr

DS: Right.

MR: and you might in your head be thinking, "This is going to be like this." And then you get there and it's something different entirely.

DS: Yeah many times, many times. Like I said you never knew what you were walking into. Like was there going to be an arranger? Is he a producer that really knows music or is he just a producer that works for the label but he doesn't know music and is expecting us to like come up with the parts and the – you just never knew. You just never knew what it was going to be.

DS: Well I'll tell you – we had a session with McCartney. Like I did the "Ram" album for instance with McCartney. McCartney was terrific but he would come in, no music, no chord changes, he wanted you to learn the song like a band. That's what he was used to. So he would play the song and you would just sit there and learn the song like a garage band. And he would do multiple takes, and he worked with the drum sound. He was very exacting and a very good producer, Paul McCartney. And probably one of the greatest melodists of all time. So he knew what he wanted, but he would do it, you know, band style. There was no – nobody wrote the changes out. Nobody wrote play this line or if there's a line here he'd show you the line and he'd say, "Would you play that while I'm doing this?" "Okay." It was like trial and error kind of thing. He had the song written.

MR: And you'd come back the next day and you're expected to remember everything that happened before?

DS: Yeah. And sometimes it would be multiple days on the same song. You know with McCartney. So that's another thing you didn't know. As a studio musician in a three hour session you were allowed to do four songs – I think a total of four songs. You couldn't try to do ten songs in a session. They limited that so that they wouldn't take advantage of the musicians, you know getting all these takes for less money or something. So you were allowed to do four songs in a three hour session. But with somebody like McCartney you could do one song for six hours one day and come back, he didn't like it, take it and then re-do it again the next day for six hours. Whatever it took.

MR: And he didn't actually have the budget constraints.

DS: No. There was no budget constraints, he's Paul McCartney you know. So, and he was terrific. I'm not putting him down in any way, shape or form. He deserves every credit he gets. He's a wonderful, natural songwriter musician.

MR: Paul Simon works in a similar fashion?

DS: Well Paul Simon worked in a similar fashion, yeah. Yes. I did "Rhymin' Simon" with Paul. He worked in a fashion like that. He might have an arranger afterwards to write string parts or something, or what they call sweetening. They'd put on violins and stuff later. But the original session with the rhythm section he would just work with you and you'd learn the song on the spot.

MR: He usually played?

DS: He usually played. He's quite a good acoustic guitar player, Paul Simon. Yeah. He's a good acoustic guitar player. So he'd play and he'd show you the song. So that's what I'm saying, you go from that let's say, to Thad Jones-Mel Lewis, now it's all written out. Two completely different ways of recording you know. And sometimes, like I said, sometimes

album in two days. You did eight, ten tracks in two days. But some of the rock stuff, the pop stuff, they were more interested in the sonic thing on it too so they'd work on drum sounds for hours. They'd work on a synth sound for hours. It was more about let's call it the soundscaping of the record. How it sounded. Moreso than just the notes you know what I mean. So it's a whole different – you have to be prepared. Are we going to play seventeen songs in three hours or one song for three days. Very different.

MR: You have to be patient then.

DS: Oh, a lot of patience. You have to be totally patient, yes. And I kind of lost my patience with some of it honestly, because I was a quick study and there were certain people I just didn't want to work with because of that. I really didn't want to sit there for two days playing the same song.

MR: You should teach in a university.

DS: I should?

MR: You should.

DS: Are you kidding me?

MR: No because you have the experience of a lot of the professors don't really have.

DS: I don't know that.

MR: Well it's just my opinion but. Now you're less into the studio scene now, but at the same time there's less of a studio scene.

DS: Oh as far as I know there's not really any. I mean most of the things are done in people's apartments. Or you could make a record in your bathroom today. I don't know. I mean I'm certainly not part of it. I mean I'm happy that I was there in the '70s. I was there at a good time. And that was lucky that I was there at a good time. And I think why I became somewhat of a first or second call guitarist in New York was because also I came in at a transition time where the guitarists at the time were playing the big jazz boxes and stuff, and they were playing heavy gauge strings and they were playing jazz. They came from a jazz world. I came from a rock & roll, rhythm & blues world. And I was playing a Telecaster. And my sound was different. The sound was starting to change you know as far as guitars. How guitars played on records and what they played. And I think because of my background of bending the strings and all this other stuff that a lot of the jazz guitarists didn't really do. And a lot of the jazz guitarists didn't really like the pop music and stuff. And I kind of liked it. So I went in with a good attitude and played in a certain way that was becoming a style, that was becoming a '70s style. So for me I think a lot of my career was because I was at the right place at the right time. And my sound was something they wanted on the record. You know? A lot of the jazz guys weren't playing with that kind of sound. And that's not to put down the jazz guys, these are my favorite

guys. But I'm saying at the time it was transitioning into a different style of guitar playing and I was right there at the time of that transition.

MR: Was your sound connected to a certain kind of amp?

DS: Yeah also like the amp, because it was a Fender amp, which is funny because I always liked the Telecaster through a Fender amp. But what happened was every studio had these Ampeg amps for some reason. Because there was a club called the Manhattan Guitar Club. Here's a funny story I'll never forget. So one of my first sessions when I stopped bringing my own amp because I was playing so many sessions, I couldn't drag an amp around to every studio. I'm playing in this one studio and I plug in this Ampeg. I didn't really love the sound but it was there, I didn't have to drag my amp so I played through it. And the guitar player next to me was in this club called the Manhattan Guitar Club. And he says, "Are you in the club?" And I said, "What club?" He said, "You know you can't play through that amp, you know you have to be in the club." I forget which guitarist it was. And I said, "What club?" And there's a key and you have to turn the key to be able to – and what you have to do is you have to give them $150 and each amp was $75 and they would put those amps in the different studios. So if you were in the club you could go around and use those amps. Now some of the engineers hotwired it without the key. So I was playing sort of through a hotwired amp and this guy said, "We'll invite you to the dinner and you should be in the club because we hear you're getting a lot of calls and you're doing a lot of work, you should be in the club." I get called to this dinner and I go. It's 40 guitar players that are all studio musicians and I'm like the newbie and they're basically saying, "Hey kid, you've got to join the club." And I wound up joining this thing called the Manhattan Guitar Club. I had to give them $150 and they put a $75 amp in two different studios and now I had the key and I didn't have to drag my – but the thing is I didn't really love the way those Ampegs sounded with my Tele. They sounded great for the bass through it, but it wasn't my favorite amp. It was really funny. But yeah I joined the club.

MR: Did the guy have two big bodyguards with him?

DS: It was like the Mafia of guitar, of the New York guitar scene.

MR: I can like imagine – like, "I'll join your club but get something besides Ampeg, will you?"

DS: Yeah. "Can't you put a Twin in here or a Concert?" I used to play through the Fender Bassman with the four ten inch. That was my sound. The Tele with the Fender Bass, four-tens. That was the real Telecaster hillbilly sound that came from down south. All the guys played like that. I loved that sound. That was my sound. That's what I was going after. And it kind of brought that to New York in a certain way.

DS: No. You don't. In fact I played on "Bye Bye Miss American Pie."

MR: That's what I was thinking.

DS: And it's really funny because I guess the producer knew that the studio musicians weren't going to tolerate playing this song over and over again for a lot so he rehearsed Don McLean for weeks by himself with his bass player, and then he called me and Paul Griffin, the piano player, to be the two studio guys on the record. So when we get there we're running it down, I'll never forget this, and I say to Don McLean, "You know you really should cut out some verses. This is really too long. This will never get on the radio." How wrong was I? I said, "You know they only go for two minutes, maybe two-thirty, maybe three minutes on a record, on a 45. This is never going to be on the radio. And the producer, I think John Simon was like, "Shut up, Spinozza, just play the part." And anyway the rest is history.

MR: And that tune has some odd measures in it every once in a while.

DS: And it also had rubato. Remember it starts like out of time? There was no records that started out of time and then went into time and then went out of time. And that long. That was a rare – how they ended up with airplay on that was amazing.

MR: Do you remember if he sang – the vocal we hear, is that the thing he was singing?

DS: Well he was singing once again what we call it the dummy vocal. He sang live with his playing but then I think he went in and fixed stuff. 'Cause like we were talking earlier, on a record, you know a record has to last a lot of listens. You can't have out of tune singing or any of this. So they would go in and fix a lot. Apparently John Simon said there was like 50 edits or something on that record. You don't hear that but that was a very put together record.

MR: Have you ever had a solo that came out that had been "put together." Like you did three or four and then the producer –

DS: Oh yeah, some. Yeah. The one solo I did that didn't get put together but it's a weird thing I don't know if you heard the Dr. John story. Do you know that story? Would you like me to tell it?

MR: Yeah.

DS: I was at Atlantic Records one day I think working on an Aretha Franklin record. And Atlanta has a main studio and then they have like a mixing room studio. And Dr. John was in the mixing room with I think – I forgot who was producing it, either Arif Mardin was working or Joel Dorn. One of those producers. I was working with both of them a lot of the time. So I was on my way to a jingle date, it was like 1:30, and I had to go to a 2:00 jingle date. I'd just finished a 10-1 at Atlantic. I'm at the elevator with my guitar and my gig bag getting ready to go to my next session. And Dr. John comes out of the mix

doing? You got a minute?" I said, "Yeah, what's up?" He said, "Man we forgot to put a sax solo on this tune. Can you come and play a little solo for me?" I said, "Okay." So I go in the mix room. There's a little amp in the corner, a little Fender thank God in the corner, mics it up, because it wasn't really a studio, it was just a little, you know we're in a studio, a little mixing room. So he said, "It's in E flat." And they rolled right to the place where I'm going to solo so I don't hear the song. There's like a four bar thing, and I go to play the solo. So I play the solo and I realized my G string was a little out of tune because I just had the guitar in a bag. And I said – so I play the solo and I played this note that I really didn't like and it's out of tune, so I bend it up to mess around, and I bend it to like an augmented fifth, which is not a great blues bend. And I play the solo and I go, "You know what? Let me try another one." "Well you said – it was magic, that was magic, get out of here." I said, "No, come on, I can play something better." "Get out of here." And they throw me out of the studio. And he said, "You're the one who said you've got to go to the next session." So I leave the studio and I felt really like oh man what the hell did I just play. You know I could have played a better solo. Two months later I'm in a taxicab, three guitars in the back. I've got my acoustic, my twelve string, my Tele, I'm going to a session. The cab – the song comes on, right time wrong place. The cab driver says, "Oh you're a guitar player, you'll love – this is my new favorite solo. He turns it up. A knee-jerk reaction I go, "That's me." He goes, "Yeah right, buddy." And he turns it down. I had to go to Colony Shop to buy the record. And I hear it – to this day I hear that over-bent note and it drives me crazy. And it became this like iconic solo.

MR: Go figure.

DS: And that was one take and they wouldn't let me play another note. I was like, "Come on, give me another shot." "Nope."

MR: And at that point you had never even heard what came before or what came after.

DS: I never heard it. I mean Mardin went, "Here's four bars, it's in E flat. Play some blues." That was it.

MR: Did you get paid for it?

DS: Yeah, oh yeah, yeah.

MR: Oh. Kismet I guess.

DS: It was one of those bizarre right time/wrong plac—right time/right place. Yeah.

MR: Have you ever had a right time/wrong – what's the worst session you ever did? The worst gig?

DS: The worst gig I ever did?

MR; The worst gig ever, anything come to mind like oh man that was just –

DS: Well I remember a gig that was a little painful as far as – at the Record Plant we were going to do I'm trying to think of his name who sang "Freedom" at Woodstock.

MR: Oh yeah, um.

DS: Jesus I can't think of his name. Losing my brain. Richie Havens.

MR: Richie Havens yeah. And it was Charlie Calello was producing Richie Havens. And Charlie was a great arranger. He did all the Four Seasons arrangements and stuff like that and you know he's the one the came up with [scats]. Great arranger. But he was producing Richie Havens. And somebody was playing drums and he was not happy with the drums, he kept changing the drum part and the drummer couldn't remember like what he wanted. And he'd start the take and we'd get to the part and he wouldn't play what Charlie wanted. And Charlie was a great arranger, really a great pop arranger. But for some reason something was happening, he wasn't happy with the drummer. And Richie was getting nervous. Richie was used to playing with folk singers and playing with guys, then all of a sudden there's a – he's being produced by Charlie Calello. And Charlie got upset with the drummer and threw his pencil down and walked out of the studio and got in the cab and left, and just left us all in the studio like – and Richie was like – I didn't know what to say to Richie. The drummer was embarrassed. And that was a strange session. And I walked out of there just feeling like wow. We were all trying to do the right thing but Charlie wasn't happy and he just slammed his pencil down on the podium and walked out and got a cab and went home. Never finished the record. That was a weird moment in the studio.

MR: Yeah. Well no one got hurt except their feelings.

DS: No. There was no blood. It wasn't Viet Nam. It's okay.

MR: So what's up next for you? How do you keep yourself busy?

DS: I'm golfing on Tuesday, I'll be skiing in the winter. That's kind of what I do now.

MR: Well you've had a hell of a career I'll tell you that.

DS: It was kind of a crazy run.

MR: Yeah. And a great example of literally playing things by ear and learning on the job, and I really respect that.

DS: Well thanks. Thank you. I didn't know it was going to be that way. I'm glad it happened.

MR: Yeah. Well thanks for your time today.

DS: Yeah. Great talking to you. And it was great playing for you last night and playing with you last night.

MR: Absolutely. That was a thrill for me. Now I can say, "Guess who I played with the other day."

DS: I could say the same thing.